priestly Sanskrit but the less ornate vernacular language of North India known as Prakrit, which carries the meaning of ‘ordinary’ or ‘artless’. Ashoka seems to have been determined that all his subjects should know what he thought and felt, using the new medium of writing.

Nearly all these first MREs are found carved on the smoothed-out walls or floors of existing rock-shelters, and all are dated, as Ashoka himself informs us, from two and a half years after he had become what he himself called an *upasake* or ‘follower of Sakya’ – in other words, a Buddhist lay-follower of Buddha Sakyamuni. He goes on to tell his readers (of whom there must have been very few at that time) that he is engaged on a 256-day tour of his dominions. He ends by calling on parents, elders and teachers to be respected, for kindness to be shown to all living things, for truth always to be spoken and for the Dharma to be promoted.[5]

Autocratic ruler though he was, Ashoka believed passionately that his interpretation of dharma was the means by which all people could live in harmony with each other, nature and the gods. It called for all religions to be respected and it remains to this day an astonishing message to come from a ruler, quite without parallel in history. It is under Ashoka’s aegis that Indian civilisation, in the sense of a shared culture embracing everything from administration to art and architecture, makes a great leap forward, with tolerance as its watchword. One of his edicts is entirely devoted to this subject, with the great emperor under his regnal name of Piyadasi calling on his subjects to respect all religions. It ends with these words:

> Whoever praises his own religion, due to excessive devotion, and condemns others with the thought ‘Let me glorify my own religion’, only harms his own religion. Therefore contact (between religions) is good. One should listen to and respect the doctrines professed by